

The Dark Continent

How fourteen nations carved a continent — and why Africa may yet redraw the map of money.

In the winter of 1884, diplomats gathered around a horseshoe table in Berlin and set the rules for the fastest, most violent land-grab in human history. No African sat among them. This is the story of that room, of the borders and the balance-sheets it bequeathed — and of a new, permissionless network now spreading across the same continent, from a feature phone in Nairobi to a hydro-powered mine in the Zambian bush.



Ratty2Tails

ESSAYS ON SOUND MONEY & EMPIRE

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“Africa had been left with artificial nations carved out at the Berlin Conference, and the continent was now struggling to build these nations into stable units of human society.”

— ATTRIBUTED TO JULIUS NYERERE, FIRST PRESIDENT OF TANZANIA

A Salon in Berlin

Picture a room. Not a battlefield, not a throne room, not a parliament — merely a formal salon on the Wilhelmstrasse, in the heart of Berlin, with high ceilings and the faint reek of cigar smoke in the curtains. It is the afternoon of Saturday, 15 November 1884. Around a horseshoe-shaped table sit the representatives of fourteen nations: ambassadors and envoys from every major European power save Switzerland, together with delegates from the United States and the Ottoman Empire. Not one of them is African. And behind them, dominating the wall like a silent witness to its own dismemberment, hangs a vast map of Africa.

One historian would later say the map drooped down like a question mark, and the image is apt, for everything about this gathering was a question mark. A question of who would own what. A question of who had the right to decide. And, most tellingly, a question nobody in the room seemed minded to ask at all: whether any of them had the right to be deciding anything.

This was the Berlin Conference. It would run for one hundred and four days, from that November afternoon until 26 February 1885, with a pause for Christmas. When the men finally rose from the table they had signed the General Act of Berlin, a document of thirty-eight clauses. Those clauses did not merely divide a continent. They laid the legal and diplomatic groundwork for conquest: a framework telling European governments precisely how to claim African territory, how to have rivals recognise the claim, and how to extract wealth from lands on which they had never set foot. The borders they set in motion, the systems they legitimised — these have not healed. They are, in a real sense, still bleeding.

The Lie of the Empty Land

To understand why fourteen nations gathered to partition a continent that was not theirs, one must first dispose of the story the colonisers told themselves — the fable, echoed in Western textbooks for a century, of a *dark continent*, an empty wilderness awaiting the improving hand of Europe. It was a fabrication built on racism and ignorance.

Before Berlin, Africa was home to some of the most sophisticated civilisations the world had known. The Mali Empire, flourishing from the thirteenth to the sixteenth century, covered an area roughly the size of Western Europe; its ruler Mansa Musa is widely reckoned the wealthiest individual in recorded history, so lavish on his 1324 pilgrimage to Mecca that the gold he scattered destabilised the economies of the cities he passed through. Timbuktu, under Mali and later Songhai, held the University of Sankoré, where scholars studied mathematics, astronomy, law and theology. Further south, Great Zimbabwe commanded gold and

ivory routes to the Indian Ocean, its stone ruins so impressive that European archaeologists invented fantasies of lost white builders rather than credit African hands. The Kingdom of Kongo kept diplomatic relations with Portugal for generations; the Kingdom of Benin cast bronzes of a refinement that baffled the very Europeans who looted them in 1897.

The Ashanti, the Zulu, the Ethiopians, the Sokoto Caliphate, the Kingdom of Buganda — these were not aimless tribes but states, with laws, economies, armies and diplomatic traditions reaching back centuries. None was invited to Berlin. The only African ruler even to request a representative, Sultan Barghash of Zanzibar, was refused — reportedly under pressure from the British Anti-Slavery Society, on the grounds that Zanzibar's part in the slave trade disqualified it. The irony is almost too bitter to swallow: nations that had shipped millions of Africans in chains across the Atlantic now barred an African sovereign from the table on *moral* grounds.

III

Rubber, Rivers and a King's Ambition

So how did a continent of empires become, to European eyes, a blank canvas for rulers and pencils? The answer begins with industry. By the mid-nineteenth century, European factories were devouring raw materials — cotton, rubber, palm oil, copper, iron, ivory — and Africa held them in abundance. For centuries European contact had been confined to coastal trading posts; the interior was marked *terra incognita*. That changed in the 1850s and '60s as explorers pressed inland: Livingstone, Burton, Speke, and most consequentially Henry Morton Stanley, whose descent of the Congo between 1874 and 1877 erased the last great blank on the map.

Stanley's reports reached one of the most dangerous men in European politics: Leopold II of Belgium. Leopold craved a colony — not for Belgium so much as for himself, a private empire. In 1876 he founded the International African Association, cloaked in the language of philanthropy and Christian civilisation. Behind the mask he hired Stanley to return, not as explorer but as agent, and between 1879 and 1885 to sign treaties with more than four hundred and fifty local rulers. Many signed with an X, illiterate and deceived; others took trinkets in exchange for what amounted to the surrender of their homelands.

France was watching. In 1881 the officer Pierre de Brazza raised the tricolour at what became Brazzaville, across the river from Leopold's ground. Portugal pressed its ancient Kongo claims; Britain, already the dominant colonial power, eyed the whole business with suspicion. Multiple powers were staking the same territories, and the risk of open war between them grew by the day. The press had a name for it: the *Scramble for Africa*.

IV

Bismarck's Horseshoe Table

Enter Otto von Bismarck, chancellor of a Germany unified only since 1871 and a practitioner of what he called *Realpolitik* — practical outcomes over moral principle. Bismarck had once dismissed African colonies

as impractical, but by 1884 the pressure to join the race had become irresistible: merchants demanded markets, the Social Democrats were gaining at home, and the rivalries between Britain, France, Portugal and Leopold offered him a chance to cast Germany as the arbiter of European affairs. In October 1884, with French support and at Portugal's initiative, he issued invitations to thirteen nations.

Three outcomes stand above the rest. The first was recognition of Leopold's *personal* claim to the Congo — an area of some nine hundred thousand square miles, home to millions, acknowledged as the private property of one man and christened, with grotesque irony, the *Congo Free State*. The second was the doctrine of *effective occupation*: a European power could claim African land by signing treaties with local rulers, presenting them at home, and demonstrating an administrative presence — a garrison, a trading post, an official. In practice this meant a race to plant flags and build forts as fast as possible, because territory not seized first would be seized by a rival. The third was the creation of free-trade zones along the Congo and Niger — colonialism dressed in the language of free enterprise.

The conference did not draw most of Africa's borders. It did something more dangerous: it wrote the rules of the game.

A common misconception holds that the map of modern Africa was drawn in that salon. It was not; a 2024 study confirms that only the borders of the Congo region were settled at the conference, and even those were later revised. Most African frontiers took shape through bilateral haggling over the following two or three decades, many finalised only after the First World War. What Berlin created was the framework — the shared legal fiction that Africa was a resource to be claimed, that its peoples had no say, and that European power politics should decide the fate of a continent.

V

Ten Per Cent to Ninety

Once the rules were set, the scramble accelerated at terrifying speed. In 1870, European powers held perhaps a tenth of African territory, mostly coastal. By 1914 — less than three decades after Berlin — they held more than ninety per cent.

1870 10%

Coastal enclaves & a few inland footholds

1914

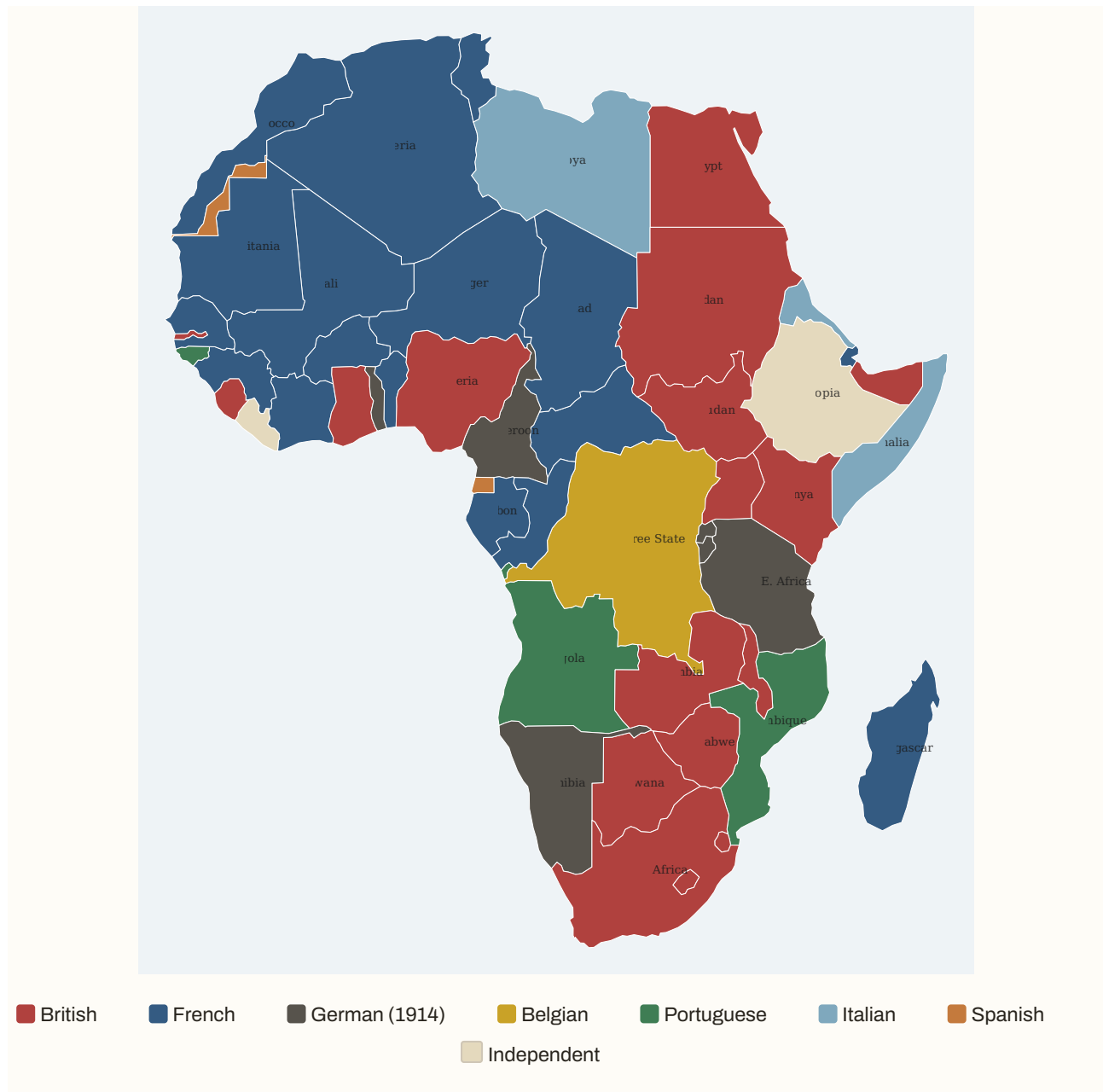
90%

Over ninety per cent under European flags

Share of African territory under European control — a partition completed in a single generation.

Figure 1 — The speed of the scramble. European control of African territory, 1870 versus 1914.

France carved out the largest domain, from Senegal and Guinea to Chad and the Congo. Britain pursued Cecil Rhodes's dream of a ribbon from the Cape to Cairo, seizing Nigeria, the Gold Coast, Kenya, Uganda, Sudan and the Rhodesias. Germany, the host, took Togoland, Kamerun, German East Africa — today Tanzania, Rwanda and Burundi — and German South West Africa, modern Namibia, where its forces would commit the first genocide of the twentieth century against the Herero and Nama. Portugal clung to Angola and Mozambique; Italy took Eritrea, part of Somalia and eventually Libya; Spain held slivers of the Western Sahara and Equatorial Guinea; and Belgium — through Leopold — held the most profitable prize of all.



Map 1 — Africa partitioned, c. 1914. Modern national outlines shaded by the imperial power that held each territory at the height of the partition, before the First World War redistributed Germany's colonies. Only Ethiopia and Liberia remained independent.

Only two African states kept their independence through the whole ordeal: Ethiopia and Liberia. Ethiopia survived because, in 1896, Emperor Menelik II destroyed an invading Italian army of seventeen thousand at the Battle of Adwa, killing or capturing over eleven thousand — the only time an African nation repelled a European colonial invasion outright, and a shock that echoed through every European capital.

VI

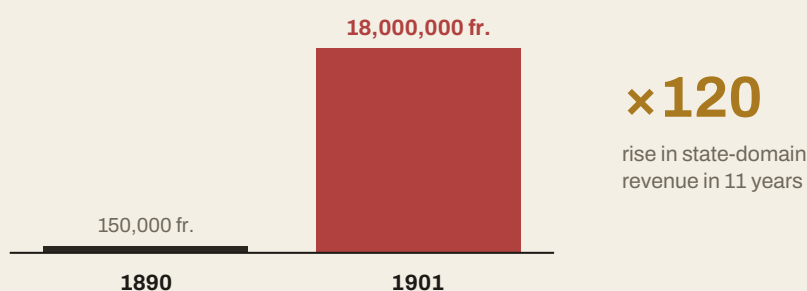
The Severed Hand

The clearest, most harrowing illustration of what Berlin unleashed is the Congo. Having secured personal control, Leopold presented himself to the world as a benevolent king bringing civilisation to Central Africa.

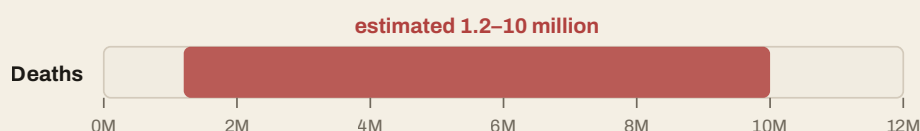
Behind the mask he built one of the most brutal regimes in modern history. By the early 1890s he had, by decree, nationalised roughly ninety-nine per cent of the Congo and its resources, carving the land into concessions and keeping a vast personal domain. The system existed to extract one thing above all: rubber. And the instrument it used was terror.

Each village was set a rubber quota. Leopold's private army, the *Force Publique* — African soldiers under European officers — enforced the quotas with violence. Villages that fell short were attacked; women and children were taken hostage until the men delivered. In the regime's most infamous cruelty, soldiers were required to account for every cartridge fired by producing a severed human hand, and baskets of hands became a routine feature of the rubber trade. Photographs of Congolese men, women and children with amputated hands would eventually shock the world.

THE PROFIT



THE PRICE



Rubber exports rose more than 500%. Leopold's personal profit, 1896–1905: roughly 70 million francs.

Figure 2 — Leopold's Congo: profit and price. State-domain revenue and the estimated human toll of the rubber terror, c. 1890–1905.

The population collapsed. Estimates of the dead range from 1.2 million at the low end to 10 million at the high, with broad agreement among historians that the decline was catastrophic — a compound of murder, starvation, disease, plunging birth rates and mass displacement. The truth surfaced only in the early 1900s, when a Liverpool shipping clerk named E. D. Morel noticed that ships left for the Congo carrying guns, chains and ammunition and returned laden with rubber and ivory, with no trade goods going the other way. What he was looking at, he realised, was not commerce but slavery. Morel quit, founded the Congo Reform Association, and was joined by Roger Casement, whose 1904 consular report documented the atrocities in devastating detail. Joseph Conrad drew on his own 1890 voyage for *Heart of Darkness*; the African-American historian George Washington Williams, writing to Leopold, is believed to have coined the phrase *crimes*

against humanity. In 1908 the Belgian state finally wrested the colony from the king. Leopold died the following year, having never once set foot in Africa.

VII

Lines That Still Bleed

The Congo was not the only wound. The frontiers drawn after Berlin were built to serve European interests, not African realities. They followed rivers, meridians and the convenience of negotiating tables in London and Paris — anything but the political, ethnic and linguistic boundaries that had defined African societies for centuries. Peoples who had lived together for generations were split between empires; peoples with no shared history were forced together inside a single artificial line.

The Somali were divided among four territories; the Ewe between the Gold Coast and Togoland; the Mandinka cut apart along colonial river boundaries; the Nuer split across what became South Sudan and Ethiopia. Nowhere is the logic more devastating than in Rwanda. Before colonisation, the terms Hutu, Tutsi and Twa were largely markers of class and occupation, fluid categories one could move between through wealth or marriage. The Belgians, taking over after the First World War, hardened them into pseudo-scientific racial castes and, in 1933, issued identity cards fixing every Rwandan permanently as Hutu, Tutsi or Twa. Six decades later, at the roadblocks of the 1994 genocide, those very cards decided who lived and who died: at least eight hundred thousand people murdered in roughly a hundred days.

The pattern repeats. Nigeria — over 220 million people, 250-plus ethnic groups, 500-plus languages — was assembled by Britain from territories with no shared identity, and paid for it with the Biafran War of 1967–70, in which between one and three million died. The Democratic Republic of the Congo, heir to Leopold's nightmare, has endured decades of war that make its east one of the deadliest places on earth since 1945. Sudan split in two in 2011, and South Sudan promptly fell into its own civil war.



Relative frequency of political violence (intact homelands = 100). Michalo

Figure 3 — Borders and bloodshed. Partitioned ethnic homelands saw markedly more political violence than those left whole.

This is not merely narrative. Research by the economists Stelios Michalopoulos and Elias Papaioannou found that African homelands partitioned by colonial borders experienced roughly fifty-seven per cent more

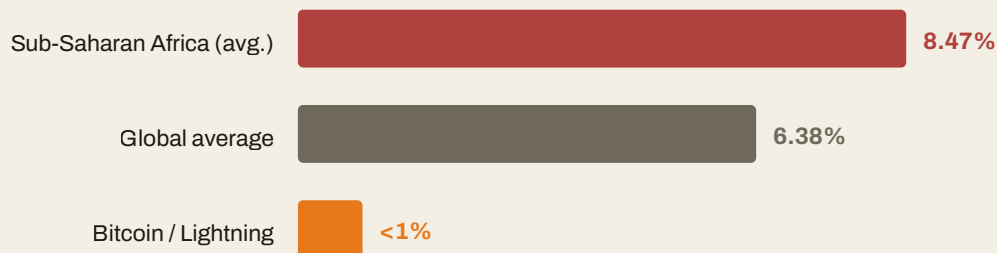
political violence than those left intact — an effect comparable in size to sitting atop petroleum, one of the most notorious drivers of conflict on the continent. When the Organisation of African Unity chose in 1963 to accept the colonial borders wholesale, reasoning that redrawing them would unleash chaos, it made a pragmatic peace with a flawed inheritance — and locked the flaw in place.

VIII

The Long Shadow of the Ledger

Here the story usually ends, with borders and grievances. But there is a second inheritance from Berlin, quieter and less discussed: a *financial* architecture built, like the borders, to serve the metropole rather than the colony. Colonial economies were engineered for extraction — raw materials out, manufactures in — and settled in the coloniser's currency, through the coloniser's banks. When independence came in the 1950s, '60s and '70s, the new states inherited not only the map but the plumbing beneath it.

Some of that plumbing survives almost intact. Fourteen African countries still use the CFA franc, a currency born of French colonial administration, pegged first to the franc and now to the euro, its monetary policy long shaped from Paris. Across the continent, sovereign debt is denominated in dollars rather than local currency, so that a devaluation abroad can gut a national budget at home. Cross-border payments run through a correspondent-banking system in which African transactions are routinely the most expensive on earth to clear — and remittances, the lifeblood of millions of families, are skimmed at rates that would be considered scandalous anywhere else.



Typical cost of sending remittances. World Bank; Lightning fees routinely under on

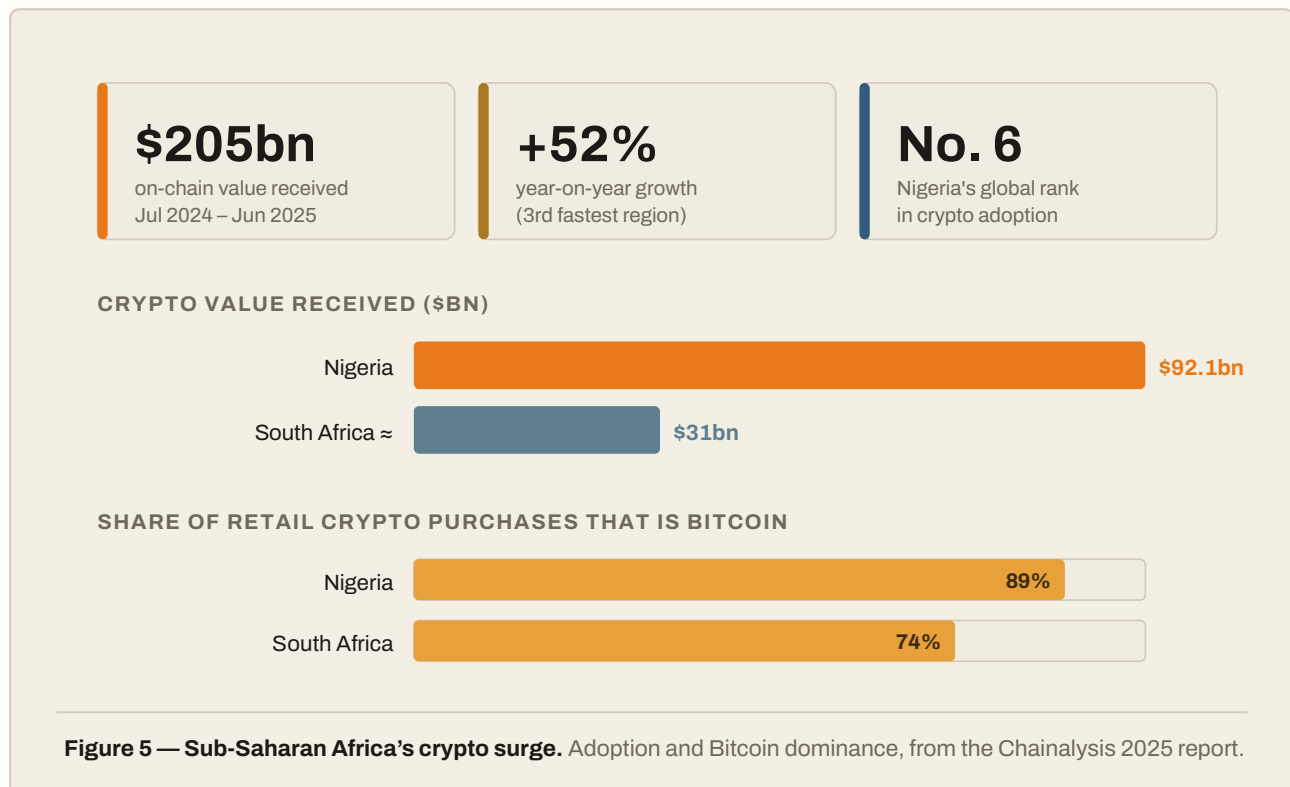
Figure 4 — The cost of sending money home. Average remittance cost by channel.

The World Bank has long put the average cost of sending money to sub-Saharan Africa near eight and a half per cent — well above the global average, itself far above the United Nations' target. For a migrant worker wiring home two hundred dollars, that is real food taken off a real table, every month, forever. It is against *this* backdrop — a continent whose money still flows along channels dug in the age of empire — that a very different kind of network has begun to spread.

IX

A Different Kind of Network

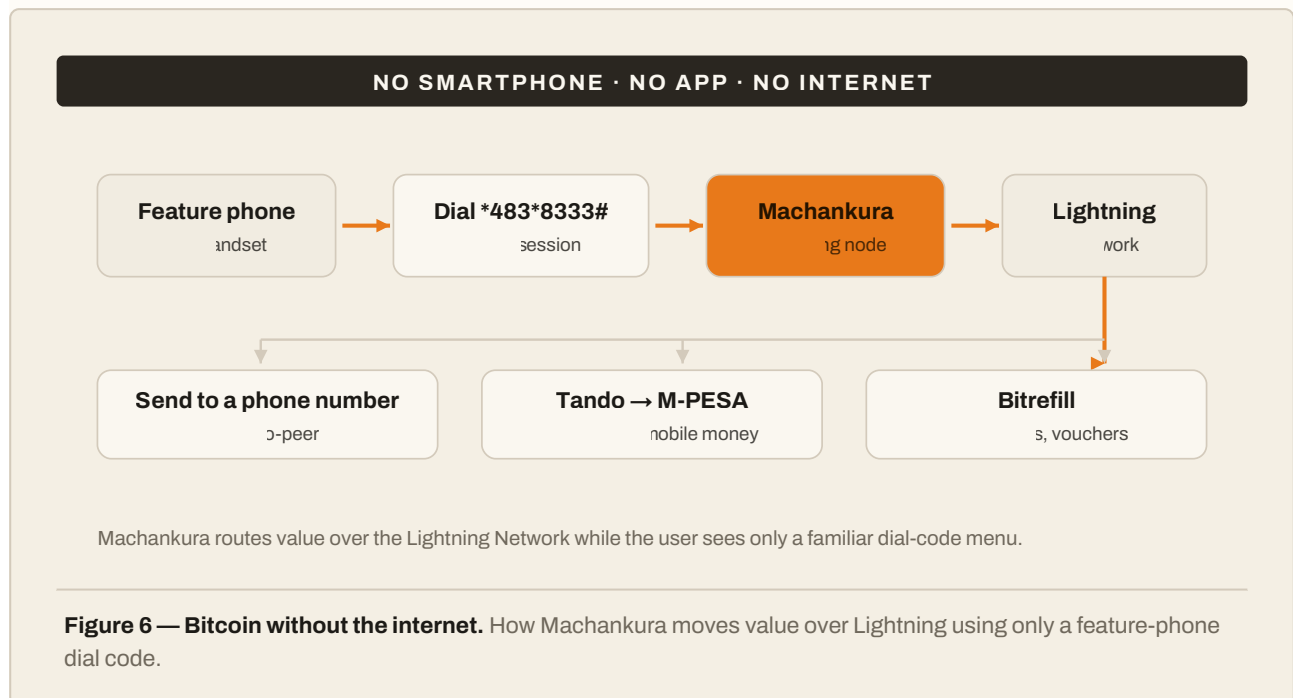
Bitcoin is often caricatured in the West as a speculative toy. In much of Africa it is something closer to its original purpose: a way to move and store value without banks, without permission, and without borders. The numbers are striking. Between July 2024 and June 2025, sub-Saharan Africa received more than 205 billion dollars in on-chain value, a 52 per cent jump on the previous year and the third-fastest growth of any region on earth, behind only the Asia-Pacific and Latin America. Nigeria alone accounted for some 92 billion dollars — sixth in the world for crypto adoption, and nearly three times the volume of South Africa. Tellingly, a larger share of value moves in small, everyday transfers here than anywhere else, and Bitcoin's dominance is greater than in any other region: it makes up 89 per cent of retail crypto purchases in Nigeria and 74 per cent in South Africa. This is not a casino. It is a hedge, a savings account and a payment rail rolled into one, reached for by people whose own currencies are losing value faster than they can earn it.



The engine of everyday use is not the Bitcoin blockchain itself — too slow and too dear for a cup of coffee — but the *Lightning Network*, a second layer that settles payments almost instantly for a fraction of a penny. Lightning is what turns Bitcoin from digital gold into digital cash, and it is what makes the African story possible.

Consider the obstacle. In 2024 the continent counted some 710 million unique mobile subscribers, yet only about 416 million — barely 28 per cent — used mobile internet. Hundreds of millions can dial a short code but cannot download an app. A South African engineer and former Amazon developer, Kgothatso Ngako, built the answer in 2022: **Machankura**, a service that puts Bitcoin on the humblest feature phone through USSD — the same dial-code menus Africans already use to buy airtime and move mobile money. No

smartphone, no app, no internet. The user dials a code, a text menu appears, and behind the scenes Machankura routes the payment over the Lightning Network.



Machankura now operates in around ten countries and runs two of the three largest Lightning nodes on the continent. Its footprint sketches a second map of Africa — not of empires, but of exit ramps from the old financial order.



Map 2 — A second map of Africa. Countries where Machankura's USSD Bitcoin service operates (highlighted). No smartphone or internet connection is required.

Around this spine, an ecosystem has grown. In Kenya, the app *Tando* converts Bitcoin into M-PESA mobile-money credit at no fee on its end, so a payment that arrives as sats can be spent as shillings. *Bitrefill* turns Bitcoin into airtime, bills and vouchers. In Nigeria, *Mavapay* runs a Lightning corridor to South Africa at 0.75 per cent — against the 2.5-to-4.5 per cent charged by conventional processors — while *Bitnob*, through a partnership with Strike, pushes cheap remittances straight into mobile-money accounts in Ghana and Kenya. The value of these tools became vivid during Tanzania's 2025 internet shutdown, when mobile-money platforms and fintechs went dark for days and a family kept moving money across the border using a Lightning wallet and a dial code, because USSD kept working when the internet did not.

Two further pieces complete the picture. The first is the *circular economy* — closed local loops where Bitcoin is earned and spent without ever touching a bank. The exemplar is **Bitcoin Ekasi**, in a township near Mossel Bay, South Africa, where the coaches of a children's surfing charity are paid in Bitcoin and spend it at some thirty local shops that have agreed to accept it, all over Lightning; the model has since inspired imitators in Zambia and Kenya. The second is *energy*. Firms like **Gridless** place small Bitcoin mines beside stranded

renewable power — a hydro plant in rural Zambia, a geothermal field in Kenya, a micro-hydro scheme in Malawi — and act as a buyer of last resort for electricity that would otherwise go to waste, helping fund the very grids that bring first-time power to remote communities. Here, remarkably, the extractive logic of Berlin is inverted: energy that once had no market becomes revenue that keeps the lights on.

x

Will the Current Turn?

So: will Bitcoin use keep rising in Africa, and will it deliver greater prosperity and independence from the Western financial system? Honesty requires holding two truths at once.

The case for a rising tide is strong. Africa is the youngest, most mobile-first continent on earth, and its people already lead the world in reaching for Bitcoin under monetary stress. The pressures that drive adoption — inflation, currency controls, expensive remittances, thin banking access — are structural, not passing. The tools are improving and, crucially, they are being built *in* Africa, for African conditions, rather than imported. When a continent invents USSD-native Bitcoin because its people carry feature phones, it is not following the technology's frontier; it is defining it.

But the sceptic's ledger is real too. Bitcoin's volatility makes it an uneasy unit for everyday pricing, and many Africans now prefer dollar-pegged *stablecoins* — USDT above all — for exactly that reason, choosing the stability of a synthetic dollar over the promise of a fixed supply. Most feature-phone services, Machankura included, are *custodial*: they reintroduce a trusted third party, the very thing Bitcoin was designed to remove, and with it the old risks of freezes and failures. USSD is unencrypted; you still need the internet somewhere to finally spend; regulation swings between tolerance and hostility, as Nigeria's on-again, off-again crackdowns attest. And no protocol, however elegant, fixes governance. Bitcoin can lower a remittance fee; it cannot draw an honest border or seat an accountable government.

Bitcoin offers Africans an exit, not an escape — optionality against a system built to extract from them, not a clean break from it.

The truest answer, then, is that adoption will very likely keep climbing, and that it will deliver *partial* independence — a growing power to save outside a debasing currency, to be paid across a border without a correspondent bank, to keep transacting when the state pulls the plug. That is not nothing. For a continent whose financial channels were dug in the age of Leopold and Rhodes, the ability to route around them is itself a quiet revolution. But prosperity is a broader project than any one technology. Bitcoin is a tool of exit and of savings; it is not, on its own, a development plan. It will matter most where it travels alongside energy, connectivity, education and the rule of law — and least where those are absent.

XI

The Question Mark, Still Hanging

The men around that horseshoe table knew almost nothing of the continent they divided; only two of the fourteen delegations had members who had ever set foot in Africa. They drew lines through deserts and kingdoms over brandy and cigars, and the currency they exchanged was not really Africa at all but Europe — the management of rivalries between Britain, France, Germany, Portugal and Belgium without a European war. Africa's people, its history, its humanity: none of it counted. What counted was which flag flew over which territory, and which company extracted which resource.

The conference lasted a hundred and four days. Its consequences have lasted more than a hundred and forty years. A continent of 1.4 billion people, holding more linguistic diversity than any other landmass and the oldest human civilisations of all, still lives within borders drawn by men who never asked its permission. The map that hung on the wall of that Berlin salon — the one that drooped, they said, like a question mark — is in a sense still hanging there. Who has the right to draw the lines? Who decides where one nation ends and another begins? Who owns the ledger, and who is allowed to keep it?

For a century and a half those questions went unanswered, because the answering was always done elsewhere, by others, on Africa's behalf. What is different now — in a hydro-powered container in Zambia, in a surf coach's Lightning wallet in Mossel Bay, in a dial code punched into a battered handset in Nairobi — is that, for the first time, some of the answering is being done in Africa, by Africans, on their own terms. The question mark is still on the wall. But at last there are hands reaching up to redraw it.



A NOTE ON SOURCES

The historical narrative draws on the standard record of the 1884–85 Berlin Conference and the partition that followed, including the work of the economists Stelios Michalopoulos and Elias Papaioannou on partitioned homelands and political violence, and David Van Reybrouck's history of the Congo. Figures on present-day Bitcoin and Lightning adoption are drawn from Chainalysis's 2025 *Geography of Cryptocurrency* report and its sub-Saharan Africa analysis; from reporting by TechCabal, Forbes, Bitcoin Magazine, Decrypt and Mariblock on Machankura, Tando, Mavapay, Bitnob, Bitcoin Ekasi and Gridless; and from GSMA data on African mobile connectivity and World Bank data on remittance costs. Historical quotations are given as commonly attributed; the reader is encouraged to consult the primary sources directly.

Written under the name **Ratty2Tails**. Original data visualisations and cartography by the author. Set in Playfair Display, EB Garamond and Archivo.